Understanding Student Engagement with Live Music: A Data-Driven Analysis of Concert Attendance at Pomona College's Music Department

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I. Introduction

Live music occupies an important place in the cultural and educational landscape of higher education. However, maintaining an engaged audience presents a persistent challenge for institutions investing in live performance programming. Students must navigate competing academic responsibilities, extracurricular commitments, social activities, and increasingly accessible forms of digital entertainment. Consequently, even when institutions offer regular opportunities to experience live music, student attendance is not necessarily consistent or predictable.

This capstone project investigates the multifaceted factors influencing student attendance at concerts hosted by Pomona College's Music Department. Working in collaboration with Professor Joti Rockwell and Concert Production Manager Audrey Dunne, I examine historical attendance records, contemporary audience engagement, and potential strategies for improving participation. By combining 16 years of attendance data with surveys and digital engagement metrics, this project seeks to develop a more comprehensive understanding of how students discover, evaluate, and ultimately decide whether to attend live musical performances.

Although an individual's interest in a particular genre or performer may influence their willingness to attend, other considerations—including scheduling, location, social relationships, awareness of upcoming events, and competing campus activities—may be equally consequential. A student might express enthusiasm for a performance but ultimately decide not to attend because of an inconvenient schedule or a lack of awareness about the event. Conversely, students who are unfamiliar with a particular genre might attend because a friend is performing or because they encounter an appealing promotional campaign. Understanding these distinctions requires examining both the motivations that encourage attendance and the structural or situational barriers that discourage it.

To investigate these questions, I have organized the project into three interconnected phases: Past, Present, and Future. These phases provide a chronological framework while also representing distinct methodological approaches to understanding audience engagement.

The first phase, *Past: Historical Data Analysis*, examines approximately 16 academic years of concert attendance records, spanning 2008–2026. By analyzing historical attendance patterns, I aim to identify changes in participation over time and investigate how institutional and external circumstances may have influenced concert attendance. Particular attention will be given to the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic, differences between performance types, and potential relationships between attendance and changes in the student population. This historical

perspective establishes a baseline for understanding the department's audience and provides context for interpreting more recent engagement patterns.

The second phase, *Present: Contemporary Data Collection and Analysis*, focuses on newer information gathered about audience motivations and promotional effectiveness. This component combines audience surveys with social media and digital engagement analytics. Surveys distributed through Qualtrics provide insight into attendees' institutional affiliations, reasons for attending, sources of event awareness, satisfaction levels, and likelihood of returning to future performances.

Future: Predictive Modeling and Strategic Recommendations builds on the historical and contemporary findings to identify opportunities for improving student participation. By integrating attendance records, survey responses, digital engagement metrics, and information about the academic calendar and competing campus activities, I hope to create a Shiny application for the Department to use moving forward.

Ultimately, this project seeks to bridge the gap between data collection and practical application, and to provide a reproducible process of understanding audiences moving forward. By examining the relationship between programming, accessibility, promotion, and student engagement, this investigation aims to provide the Pomona College Music Department with an evidence-based, interactive framework for understanding its audiences and strengthening its connection with the campus community.

II. Literature Review

This section synthesizes existing scholarship on concert attendance behavior, audience motivations, and digital engagement strategies. It establishes the theoretical and methodological foundation for interpreting the project's historical attendance records, survey findings, and social media analytics.

III. Past: Historical Data Analysis (2008–2023)

This section examines approximately fifteen years of Pomona College Music Department concert attendance records. It investigates long-term attendance patterns, the effects of COVID-19, differences across concert types, and potential relationships between student population changes, academic scheduling, and audience participation.

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IV. Present: Contemporary Data Collection and Analysis

While historical data illuminates long-term trends and structural factors, it cannot fully reveal the immediate motivations, barriers, and decision-making processes that shape individual students' choices about concert attendance. The second phase of my project addresses this limitation by collecting contemporary data through audience surveys and social media analytics. This present-focused investigation examines the current landscape of audience engagement, documenting both quantitative measures of digital and in-person participation and qualitative insights into attendees' subjective experiences and perspectives.

I developed a post-concert feedback survey in Qualtrics, distributed through QR codes in programs and via email. The survey incorporates quantitative rating scales and multiple-choice questions designed to capture different dimensions of the concert experience, including whether respondents are first-time or returning attendees, what factors motivated their decision to attend, how they learned about the concert, their institutional affiliation, their satisfaction with the performance, whether they attended alone or with others, and their likelihood of attending future concerts.

The current survey export contains 153 submissions, of which 135 are marked as completed responses; a breakdown of the results can be found below. These findings suggest that the department's established audience extends considerably beyond its immediate student population, raising important questions about how programming and promotional strategies might better engage Pomona students.

The survey data also provides insight into audience satisfaction, the motivations that bring audiences to concerts, and patterns in how audiences discover upcoming concerts. Notably, knowing a participant is not the only significant motivation: a substantial proportion of respondents attend because they enjoy concerts generally or are interested in the musical programming itself. This distinction is important when considering strategies for attracting students who may not personally know anyone participating in a given performance.

However, the predominance of printed materials should be interpreted in the context of the audience composition: because a substantial proportion of respondents are not current students, these results do not necessarily establish which promotional channels are most effective specifically among Pomona undergraduates.

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The survey further provides insight into the social dimensions of concert attendance. Approximately 65.2% of respondents reported attending with others, compared with 34.8% who attended alone. This distribution suggests that concertgoing frequently occurs as a shared social experience, although a substantial proportion of attendees are also comfortable attending independently. Personal relationships may therefore represent an important avenue for audience development, particularly when students invite friends or attend performances featuring people they know.

Complementing these survey findings, I am conducting a systematic analysis of social media and digital engagement analytics to understand how promotional activity relates to physical attendance. By examining data from Facebook, Instagram, Google Dashboard, and Bitly, I aim to track metrics such as post reach, impressions, likes, comments, shares, story views, link clicks, and profile visits. Visualizing these data alongside attendance figures will allow me to assess which content types generate the most meaningful engagement, whether increased digital visibility corresponds with higher concert turnout, and how different platforms vary in their effectiveness.

Ultimately, the preliminary findings suggest that the Music Department faces two related but distinct challenges: maintaining its established audience and expanding its reach among students. High satisfaction ratings and strong stated intentions to return indicate that existing attendees generally value the concert experience. However, the relatively small proportion of current Pomona students represented in the survey suggests that the department may benefit from more targeted efforts to increase student awareness and participation. By combining audience feedback with historical attendance records and digital engagement analytics, this phase provides a foundation for developing more informed strategies for audience development.

Breakdown of Survey Responses

The following analysis uses the 135 submissions marked as complete in the current Qualtrics export. Percentages are calculated using 135 as the denominator unless otherwise indicated. Questions allowing multiple selections may therefore have percentages that sum to more than 100%.

First-Time vs. Returning Attendees

One of the survey's response options allowed attendees to identify that the concert was their first at the Music Department. Fifteen respondents (11.1%) selected the option, "Not applicable, this is my first concert here."

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This finding suggests that the survey captured both returning audience members and individuals encountering the department's programming for the first time. The presence of first-time attendees is important because it demonstrates that the department is reaching at least some new audiences. However, the proportion also raises questions about how effectively these first-time attendees are converted into returning participants.

Institutional Affiliation

The institutional affiliation responses reveal that the Music Department's audience extends well beyond Pomona's student population.

- Pomona College students: 26 (19.3%)
- Harvey Mudd College students: 5 (3.7%)
- Pitzer College students: 2 (1.5%)
- Claremont McKenna College students: 2 (1.5%)
- Other affiliations: 67 (49.6%)
- Consortium employees: 14 (10.4%)
- Parents: 13 (9.6%)
- Individuals not connected to the Consortium: 6 (4.4%)

Current Pomona students represent approximately one-fifth of respondents, while students from the other Claremont Colleges account for another 6.7%. The remaining respondents identify with other institutional or community affiliations.

This distribution has significant implications for promotional strategy and the evaluation of student attendance. Rather than assuming that the department's concerts primarily serve an undergraduate audience, these findings demonstrate the importance of considering the broader community when assessing attendance patterns.

Music Major Status

- Music majors: 3 (2.2%)
- Non-music majors: 39 (28.9%)
- Undecided: 3 (2.2%)
- Non-students: 90 (66.7%)

How Attendees Heard About Concerts

- Flyers/Printed Materials: 76 selections (56.3%)
- Word of Mouth: 52 selections (38.5%)

- Social Media: 41 selections (30.4%)
- Class: 6 selections (4.4%)
- Required Attendance: 3 selections (2.2%)
- Happened to Wander In: 3 selections (2.2%)

Flyers and printed materials were the most frequently reported means of discovering concerts, followed by word of mouth and social media.

These findings suggest that traditional promotional methods remain important, even alongside the department's digital outreach efforts. Word of mouth is also particularly notable, as it indicates the potential influence of interpersonal relationships in generating concert attendance.

However, these results should be interpreted in relation to the overall audience composition. Because most respondents were not current students, additional research is needed to determine whether promotional channels that effectively reach the broader community are equally effective at reaching Pomona undergraduates.

What Motivated Attendees to Attend

Respondents identified the following motivations for attending:

- General enjoyment of concerts: 84 selections (62.2%)
- Interest in the type of concert: 53 selections (39.3%)
- Knowing a participant in the concert: 44 selections (32.6%)
- Class credit: 3 selections (2.2%)
- First concert at the Music Department: 15 selections (11.1%)

These findings suggest that audience engagement is not dependent on a single motivation. Rather, attendees may be drawn to performances through a combination of personal interests, social connections, and an established appreciation for live music. This creates opportunities for the department to develop programming and outreach strategies that appeal to both existing concertgoers and individuals who may be unfamiliar with particular musical traditions.

Attending Alone vs. With Others

- Attending with others: 88 respondents (65.2%)
- Attending alone: 47 respondents (34.8%)

Approximately two-thirds of respondents attended concerts with other people. This suggests that social relationships may play an important role in the concertgoing experience.

For student audiences in particular, opportunities to attend performances with friends, classmates, or fellow extracurricular participants may help make concerts more accessible and appealing. However, additional demographic analysis would be necessary to establish whether students are more likely than community members to attend in groups.

Overall Satisfaction Level

Respondents rated their concert experience on a scale from 0 to 100.

- Mean: 93.29
- Median: 95
- Standard deviation: 7.54
- Range: 59–100
- Completed responses: 135

Likelihood of Attending Future Concerts

Respondents were also asked to indicate whether they would attend another Music Department concert.

- Definitely yes: 117 respondents (86.7%)
- Probably yes: 11 respondents (8.1%)
- Might or might not: 6 respondents (4.4%)
- Definitely not: 1 respondent (0.7%)

Combined, 128 respondents (94.8%) indicated that they would probably or definitely attend another concert.

This finding reinforces the positive satisfaction results and suggests that the department has a strong foundation for retaining its existing audience. Nevertheless, the distinction between stated intentions and actual future attendance remains important. Tracking whether respondents return to subsequent performances could provide a more meaningful measure of audience retention.

V. Future: Predictive Modeling and Strategic Recommendations

This section explores opportunities to use historical and contemporary data to anticipate attendance patterns and develop actionable recommendations. It considers predictive modeling,

improvements to longitudinal data collection, promotional strategies, and mechanisms for attracting and retaining student audiences.

VI. Conclusion

This section synthesizes the findings across the Past, Present, and Future phases, evaluates the project's contributions and limitations, and considers the implications of data-driven audience development for the Pomona College Music Department.

VII. Bibliography

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